

SMALL WORDS, LARGE WARMTH

20 Little Phrases that Make Japanese *Smile*

A pocket guide to the small things worth saying

20 PHRASES · 4 CHAPTERS · ONE PER PAGE

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*You don't need fluent Japanese.
You need one small sentence, at the right moment.*

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HOW A PAGE WORKS

The phrase, large, in Japanese and in letters you can read — then *when* to say it and *why* it tends to land, with one whisper from the Pocket Kobito.

THE ONLY RULE

Nothing here is a trick. Each phrase simply notices something a Japanese person is quietly proud of, and says so.

CHAPTER 01 OF 04

At the Counter

The five seconds between a customer and the person serving them

袋、上手に詰めてくれてありがとうございます うございます

Fukuro, jōzu ni tsumete kurete arigatō gozaimasu

/foo·koo·roh, joh·zoo nee tsoo·meh·teh koo·reh·teh ah·ree·gah·toh
goh·zai·mahs/

WHEN

The moment your bag is handed back at a convenience store or supermarket register.

WHY IT LANDS

Bagging is a quiet craft here — soft things on top, hot and cold kept apart — and almost no customer ever mentions it. Naming the skill turns a five-second handoff into a moment someone was actually seen.

*Look at the bag, not the clerk, when you say it. Reads less like flattery that way. — POCKET
KOBITO*

このスープ、何時間も炊いて るんですか

Kono sūpu, nanjikan mo taiteru n desu ka

/koh·noh soo·poh, nahn·jee·kahn moh tah·teh·roo n dess kah/

WHEN

Partway through a bowl of ramen, broth still warm on your tongue.

WHY IT LANDS

You're guessing at hours of prep most customers never think about. A cook who spent all night on stock notices the one guest who wonders about the night.

Guess a number if you like — “twelve hours?” lands bigger than the question alone. —

POCKET KOBITO

おまけしてくれるんですか、ありがとう
ございます

Omake shite kureru n desu ka, arigatō gozaimasu

/oh·mah·keh shteh koo·reh·roo n dess kah, ah·ree·gah·toh
goh·zai·mahs/

WHEN

A market or shop owner slips something free into your bag.

WHY IT LANDS

The extra is small on purpose — it's not a deal, it's warmth. Naming it out loud, instead of just nodding, hands the warmth back.

A little surprised laugh in your voice works better than a bow. — POCKET KOBITO

この盛り付け、きれいで すね

Kono moritsuke, kirei desu ne

/koh·noh moh·ree·tsoo·keh, kee·rye dess neh/

WHEN

The instant a dish is set down in front of you, before the first bite.

WHY IT LANDS

Most compliments arrive after the food is gone and only mention taste. This one lands before you've touched it, and praises the part of the work that disappears first.

*Say it before you pick up your chopsticks — the timing is the whole compliment. — POCKET
KOBITO*

深夜まで開いてて、本当に助 かります

Shinya made aitetete, hontō ni tasukarimasu

/sheen·yah mah·deh eye·teh·teh, hohn·toh nee tah·soo·kah·ree·mahs/

WHEN

Stepping into a convenience store well after midnight.

WHY IT LANDS

A konbini staying open all night is so normal here that no one thanks it anymore. Treating it as a kindness instead of a given is the surprise.

*Say it to the register, not the automatic doors — it's the person you mean. — POCKET
KOBITO*

CHAPTER 02 OF 04

Small Mastery

For the people who are quietly very good at what they do

マスター、こだわりのコーヒーな んですね

Masutā, kodawari no kōhī nan desu ne

/mah·stah, koh·dah·wah·ree noh koh·hee nahn dess neh/

WHEN

An old-style kissaten, the owner working a syphon by hand behind the counter.

WHY IT LANDS

“Master” is the word regulars use, not tourists. Naming the care rather than just the taste tells him you know exactly what kind of shop this is.

Watch him work before you say it — it should land like a conclusion, not an opener. —

POCKET KOBITO

ここ、何代目なんです か

Koko, nandaime nan desu ka

/koh·koh, nahn·dai·meh nahn dess kah/

WHEN

A shop or restaurant that clearly carries decades of history.

WHY IT LANDS

Asking about lineage, not just history, treats the shop like a family — which for its owner, it is. Old shops are quietly proud of the number.

If they answer, react to the number. “Sandaime” deserves an impressed sound out of you. —

POCKET KOBITO

尊敬します、その 技

Sonkei shimasu, sono waza

/sohn·kay shee·mahs, soh·noh wah·zah/

WHEN

Watching a craftsperson or cook execute something clearly difficult, up close.

WHY IT LANDS

“Waza” means a technique built over years, not just a skill. Naming it as waza, instead of just saying “sugoi,” tells them you’re seeing the years behind the motion, not just the moment.

Let your eyes go to the hands or the tool as you say it, not your finger. — POCKET KOBITO

これ、手作りですか、温かみがありますね

Kore, tezukuri desu ka, atatakami ga arimasu ne

/koh·reh, teh·zoo·koo·ree dess kah, ah·tah·tah·kah·mee gah
ah·ree·mahs neh/

WHEN

Holding a handmade item — pottery, a wrapped sweet, a stitched pouch — before buying it.

WHY IT LANDS

“Atatakami” names the exact thing a machine can’t fake. It tells the maker their hand is visible in the object, not just its function.

Turn the object over while you say it — show you’re actually looking, not just talking. —

POCKET KOBITO

カウンター、好きなんです

Kauntā, suki nan desu

/kah·oon·tah, soo·kee nahn dess/

WHEN

Sitting alone at a counter-style shokudō or ramen shop, instead of a table.

WHY IT LANDS

Counter seats are for people who want to watch the cooking and don't need company. Saying you chose it on purpose tells the cook you're there for the whole thing, not just the food.

*Best said to whoever's cooking right in front of you, not the person who seated you. — POCKET
KOBITO*

CHAPTER 03 OF 04

Among Friends

Once you're not a tourist to them anymore

この地域の方で「ありがとう」ってなんて言うんですか

Kono chiiki no hōgen de “arigatō” tte nante iu n desu ka

/koh·noh chee·ee·kee noh hoh·gehn deh ah·ree·gah·toh teh nahn·teh
yoo n dess kah/

WHEN

Traveling outside Tokyo, mid-conversation with someone local.

WHY IT LANDS

You're asking about the region, not textbook Japanese — dialect is usually kept for people from there. Someone proud of their hometown teaches it happily.

Actually use the word once you learn it, even badly. That's the whole point of asking. —

POCKET KOBITO

いつもの感じでお願いします

Itsumo no kanji de onegaishimasu

/ee·tsoo·moh noh kahn·jee deh oh·neh·gai·shee·mahs/

WHEN

A second or third visit to the same salon, bar, or small restaurant.

WHY IT LANDS

It's the phrase regulars use, and it hands over trust the way “omakase” does — while also quietly saying “I've been here before, and I'm coming back.”

Only works from visit two onward. On visit one, it just causes confusion. — POCKET KOBITO

今日は奢ります、乾杯

Kyō wa ogorimasu, kanpai

/kyoh wah oh·goh·ree·mahs, kahn·pie/

WHEN

The start of a group meal or drinking session.

WHY IT LANDS

Visitors are usually the ones treated in Japan, rarely the other way around.

Offering to pay flips the dynamic, and the whole table notices at once.

Say it right as glasses are being raised, not before — it should land as a surprise, not a plan. —

POCKET KOBITO

乾杯の音頭、お願いできますか

Kanpai no ondo, onegai dekimasu ka

/kahn·pie noh ohn·doh, oh·neh·gai deh·kee·mahs kah/

WHEN

Right before a group meal or party begins.

WHY IT LANDS

Leading the toast is a small honor here, usually given to the most senior person at the table. Handing it to someone else, as a guest, quietly says “you matter more here than I do.”

*Pick someone older or clearly in charge — the honor only works if it's real. — POCKET
KOBITO*

お花見、一緒にどう ですか

Ohanami, issho ni dō desu ka

/oh·hah·nah·mee, ee·shoh nee doh dess kah/

WHEN

Cherry blossom season, talking to a neighbor, coworker, or new local friend.

WHY IT LANDS

Hanami is usually something you're invited into, as the visitor. Inviting someone else — turning host for a day — quietly moves you from guest to local.

*Bring your own snack to offer. It makes the invitation real, not just polite. — POCKET
KOBITO*

CHAPTER 04 OF 04

Quiet Moments

Said mostly to no one, and meant anyway

今年の紅葉、きれいですね

Kotoshi no kōyō, kirei desu ne

/koh·toh·shee noh koh·yoh, kee·rye dess neh/

WHEN

Autumn, looking at the turning leaves with someone nearby.

WHY IT LANDS

“Kōyō” is the season’s own word, not just “leaves” — using it shows you’re tracking the calendar the way locals do, not just admiring color.

Say “*kotoshi wa*” — “*this year*” — like you’re comparing it to other years. You don’t need to have seen any. — *POCKET KOBITO*

静かでもいいですね、この神社

Shizuka de ii desu ne, kono jinja

/shee-zoo-kah deh ee dess neh, koh-noh jeen-jah/

WHEN

A small, uncrowded shrine, away from the famous ones.

WHY IT LANDS

Most visitor comments about shrines mention grandeur or history. Praising the quiet instead tells a local you understand what the place is actually for.

Say it almost at a whisper — the volume is part of the compliment. — POCKET KOBITO

浴衣、似合ってますね

Yukata, niatte masu ne

/yoo·kah·tah, nee·aht·teh mahs neh/

WHEN

Seeing a friend, or someone in your own group, dressed in a yukata at a summer festival or hot-spring town.

WHY IT LANDS

Everyone photographs people in yukata. Almost no one says the compliment out loud to the person actually wearing it.

Say it to someone you're already with, in passing — not as a photo request to a stranger. —

POCKET KOBITO

いいにおい

Ii nioi

/ee ee nee·oh·ee/

WHEN

Passing a food stall, a bakery, or someone's cooking, before you've even seen the food.

WHY IT LANDS

It's a reflex, not a review — said before you know what you're smelling. That's exactly why it reads as sincere.

*Say it half under your breath, to yourself. If they hear it, that's the bonus. — POCKET
KOBITO*

やばい、これ

Yabai, kore

/yah·bye, koh·reh/

WHEN

The moment something is far better, weirder, or more impressive than you expected.

WHY IT LANDS

“Yabai” used to mean “dangerous”; now it covers almost anything overwhelming, good or bad. Younger staff especially light up hearing a visitor use it naturally.

Let the sentence trail off. Finishing it with an actual word ruins the effect. – POCKET KOBITO

COLOPHON

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Twenty phrases chosen from sixty, by asking one question of each: would the Japanese person hearing it be quietly pleased?

また、いい旅を

MATA, II TABI O – SAFE TRAVELS, AND MAY THEY BE GOOD ONES